MOVE AND BELONG

Your first 90 days in a new town, and how to spend them so the place feels like home for the next twenty years.



Mark and Betsy Scott



Mark and Betsy Scott, the family behind Florida Coastal.

THE BOXES ARE THE EASY PART

Your first 90 days in a new town decide how the next ten years feel. Put the work in up front, on purpose, and the friendships you make will carry you for a long time.

The hard part of a move is the first Tuesday night with nothing on the calendar and nobody to call. Almost everyone hits that wall, and most people wait for it to fix itself. It rarely does.

We picked our Florida town in two weeks with three young kids, and we have lived on this coast for twenty years since. What follows is exactly what we would tell a friend who just signed the papers.

Mark and Betsy Scott

IN THIS GUIDE

Five rules for your first three months

The dip, when the newness wears off

Florida: seasons, storms and the water

Your version: kids, retiring, remote, solo or a couple

A 90 day plan and a page for your people

A paperwork checklist for your first 30 days

1 PLAN TO BE EXHAUSTED FOR 90 DAYS

For your first three months, you should be tired. Like anything worth having, you put the work in up front so you can enjoy it for a long time after.

Being new is a window, and it closes. Right now "we just moved here" opens every door. A year from now you are just someone who lives here.

Friendship takes real hours, so fill the calendar on purpose. A University of Kansas study by Jeffrey Hall (2018) counted how many hours together it takes to go from acquaintance to friend.

50
hours to a casual friend

90
hours to a real friend

200+
hours to a close friend

WHAT THAT LOOKS LIKE

Fill the calendar. Something social four or five days a week. Treat it like starting a new job: temporary, and it pays off for years.

Say yes to every invitation for 90 days, even the ones you're lukewarm on.

Meet your street in week one. Knock, bring something small and ask what they love about living here. These are the people you call when a storm is coming.

Follow up within 24 hours. Keep a note on your phone of every name, where you met and one detail, then text the next day. The second meeting is where friendships are made, and almost nobody asks for it.

Show up early, stay late. The real conversations happen while you set up the chairs and while you stack them.



A Saturday on the Gulf.

2 JOIN THREE COMMUNITIES. THEN GET INVOLVED

Pick three groups that meet in person on a schedule, from three different parts of life. Each one opens a different circle of people.

SERVE SOMETHING

You meet the people who run the town and seem to know everyone.

TRY *Rotary, Kiwanis, Lions Club, the chamber of commerce, Habitat for Humanity.*

BELIEVE SOMETHING

A weekly rhythm, real care for newcomers, and every age in one room.

TRY *A church or synagogue, a small group or Bible study, a service team on Sunday mornings.*

PLAY SOMETHING

Fun, low pressure, and the same faces every single week.

TRY *A pickleball league, run club, golf league, sailing or fishing club, choir, softball, a book club.*

Showing up is step one. Getting involved is what makes it work.

In your first month, ask each group what they need help with and say yes to one small job: greeter, setup crew, the person with the sign up sheet. People with a role meet everyone.

Give each group three tries before you decide it isn't for you. One visit tells you nothing, and ten groups once makes acquaintances while three groups every week makes friends.

3 START WITH WHAT YOU LOVE



An evening paddle, same time most nights.

Don't invent a new life from scratch. Find the people who already gather around the things you love doing. Shared interest does the hard part of the conversation for you.

1. Write down five things you love or have always wanted to try. Fishing, tennis, gardening, painting, cooking, history, dogs, live music, boats.
2. For each one, search your town plus the thing plus "club", "league" or "group". Most towns have more than you would guess.
3. Check where groups post: Meetup, local Facebook groups, Nextdoor, the parks and recreation calendar, the library events page, the chamber calendar.
4. Go to the next meeting of the two that sound best.

Go alone if you have to. *Especially* if you have to.

4 BECOME A REGULAR

Same places, same time, every week. Familiar faces turn into hellos, hellos into conversations, conversations into friends, and nobody has to make plans.

A coffee shop at the same hour most mornings. Learn the names behind the counter.

The farmers market every Saturday. Same vendors, same neighbors.

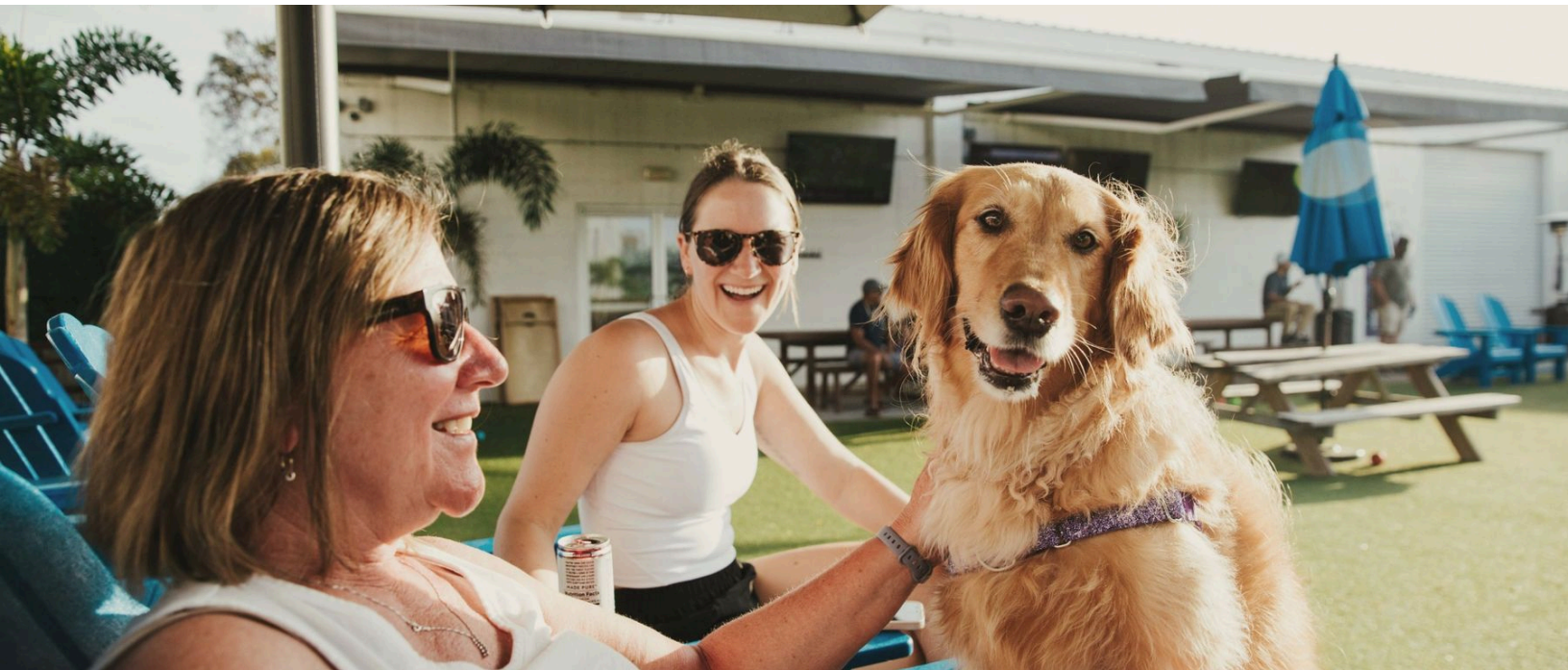
A class or a tee time, not random visits. The class is the community.

One local spot for a weeknight dinner. Sit at the bar, not a table.

The same walk with the dog at the same time each day. Dog people talk.

Within 90 days, someone in town says *"there you are"* when you walk in.

A regular Thursday on the patio.



5 DON'T WAIT FOR AN INVITE. BE THE HOST

Most people in a new town wait to be invited. Almost everyone else is waiting too. Hosting dinners is one of the fastest ways we have found to get woven into a place, because the host ends up at the center of the table.

People remember who had them over first.

Keep it simple. Tacos, a big pot of something, burgers on the grill. Nobody remembers the menu. They remember that you asked.

Mix your circles. Two people from pickleball, a couple from church, the neighbors across the street. You become the one who connects everyone, and connectors get invited everywhere.

Ask everyone to bring someone. Your table grows every time, and your guests get to show off a friend.

Make it a standing thing. First Friday dinners, Sunday porch drinks, a monthly game night. A rhythm beats one big party, because people start planning around it.

Start small if it feels like a lot. Four people is a dinner party. Cooking gives you something to do with your hands while everyone gets comfortable.

A backyard crawfish boil.

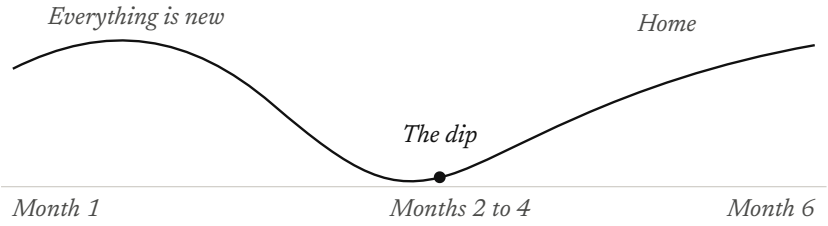




A quiet evening, a few months in.

THE DIP IS NORMAL

Somewhere after the first month, a lot of people feel worse, not better. The boxes are unpacked, the newness has worn off, and the people you have met are still acquaintances. It is the most common time to wonder if you made a mistake. You didn't.



People who study moves and culture shock have described the same curve for decades: excitement, then a slump, then things settle. The dip means you are in the middle, not that it isn't working.

WHAT HELPS

Expect it. Put a note on your calendar around day 60 that says "this is the dip." Naming it takes a lot of the sting out.

No big decisions in the dip. Don't judge the move, list the house or plan the move back while you are at the bottom of the curve. Give it six months.

Get outside early. A sunrise walk on the beach or a paddle before work does more for a rough week than another night on the couch.

Keep the routine anyway. Same spots, same groups, same nights, especially when you don't feel like going. This is exactly when the hours from Rule 1 add up.

Call home, but don't hide there. Old friends are a lifeline. Just don't let them fill the nights your new town needs.

Know when it's more than the dip. If low feelings last for weeks and get in the way of daily life, talk to a doctor or counselor. If you ever feel hopeless, call or text 988.

BELONGING IN A FLORIDA BEACH TOWN

Time your arrival to the season. In many coastal towns, clubs and leagues are busiest from fall through spring, when seasonal residents are back, and quieter in the summer heat. Arrive in late summer or early fall and you join as everything kicks off. Arrive in June and lean harder on the year round groups.

Meet both kinds of neighbors. Seasonal residents are some of the most social people in town, but they leave in spring. Make sure one of your three communities is mostly full time locals, so your circle doesn't empty out every May.

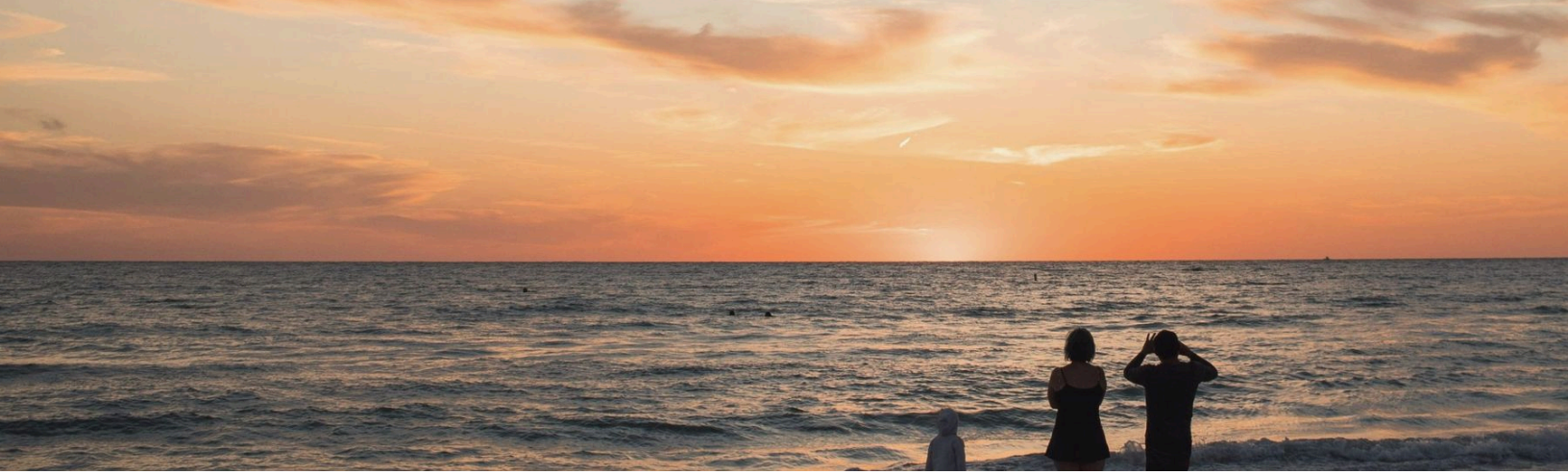
Join a water community. The water is what brings people together here: a fishing club, a sailing or paddle group, a boat club, kayak meetups, a beach cleanup crew like Surfrider, or a sea turtle nesting patrol. Turtle patrols walk the beach at sunrise in season and always need volunteers.

Build your storm circle before you need it. Hurricane season runs June 1 to November 30. The neighbors who help with shutters, share a generator or check your house when you evacuate are the ones you met in your first 90 days. Offer to help on their house first.

Go where locals go. Tourist spots are full of people leaving on Saturday. The bait shop, the hardware store, the Friday fish fry at the church or the VFW, the high school football game: that is where the people who stay are.

A dolphin off the dock.





Sunset on the Gulf.

SAME RULES, YOUR VERSION

MOVING WITH KIDS

Enroll early. Florida schools ask for a school entry health exam from the past year and Form DH 680, the state immunization certificate, from a Florida doctor or the county health department. Bring old shot records.

One team in month one. Rec league, swim team, Scouts. Sideline parents become your first friends.

Volunteer at school once. Room parent, PTA, the booster club. One morning gets you on every parent text thread.

RETIRING HERE

Take a class. Osher Lifelong Learning Institutes run courses for adults 50 and up at FSU, USF, FAU, Ringling College and more.

Volunteer on a schedule. Florida State Parks, Guardian ad Litem, Habitat, the hospital auxiliary. A standing shift beats a one time event.

Rebuild the week. Work used to hand you structure and people. Put something fixed on three mornings a week.

WORKING REMOTE

Get out of the house. No office means no default friends. A coworking desk or the same coffee shop two days a week.

Find the under 40 crowd. Chamber young professionals groups, run clubs, rec softball and kickball.

Protect your evenings. Laptop closed by six on league nights.

MOVING SOLO

Pick groups with something to do. Run clubs, sports leagues, a young adults group, a volunteer crew. The activity takes the pressure off talking.

Ask "who else should I meet?" Every new friend knows three more people. Let them introduce you.

Say you came alone. Locals adopt solo newcomers for holidays and Sunday dinners. Plan your first Thanksgiving early, or host one.

MOVING AS A COUPLE

Watch the "we have each other" trap. Staying in together is comfortable, and it quietly stalls the whole move.

Keep one group each. Share two communities and keep one of your own. Twice the circles.

Look out for whoever isn't at an office. The partner with a job meets people by default. The one at home needs their three groups first.

THE PLAN

YOUR FIRST 90 DAYS

By day 90: three communities, a few regular spots and a handful of people you could call on a Tuesday.

WEEKS 1 AND 2 *Show up*

- ☐ Meet the neighbors on both sides and across the street
- ☐ Get a library card and pick up the local paper
- ☐ List five things you love and search for groups around each
- ☐ Pick your coffee shop and your Saturday morning spot
- ☐ Start a phone note: names, where you met, one detail

WEEKS 3 AND 4 *Join*

- ☐ Go to a first meeting of all three: serve, believe, play
- ☐ Ask about a Newcomers Club or chamber newcomer event
- ☐ Text everyone you met within 24 hours
- ☐ Say yes to every invitation

MONTH 2 *Get involved*

- ☐ Take one small job in each group
- ☐ Host your first dinner, with people from all three groups
- ☐ Go to each group a third time before deciding
- ☐ Second coffee with the three people you clicked with most

MONTH 3 *Go deeper*

- ☐ Swap any group that isn't working for a new one
- ☐ Invite a new friend to something you already do
- ☐ Ask a neighbor how they prep for storm season, and help
- ☐ Look back at your names list. Who do you want more time with?

YOUR PEOPLE

SERVE
Group, when it meets, my first visit

BELIEVE
Group, when it meets, my first visit

PLAY
Group, when it meets, my first visit

MY REGULAR SPOTS

NAME	WHERE WE MET	ONE DETAIL	FOLLOWED UP

YOUR FIRST 30 DAYS

GET THE PAPERWORK OUT OF THE WAY

Belonging is easier when the boring stuff is handled. Knock this list out early so your evenings are free for people.

Driver license: within 30 days of becoming a Florida resident. Register to vote while you are there.

Car title and registration: within 10 days of becoming a resident. You need a Florida auto insurance policy first.

Homestead exemption: if you own the home and it is your primary residence on January 1, file with the county property appraiser by March 1. It lowers your property taxes and is easy to miss your first year.

Your evacuation zone: look it up at floridadisaster.org/knowyourzone. Zones are based on storm surge, so it is about more than distance to the beach.

Flood coverage: standard homeowners policies usually do not cover flood. Ask your agent before storm season, not during it.

A doctor and a dentist: book a new patient visit now. Waits in growing towns can run weeks, and you do not want to be searching when you are sick.

Library card and local news: free, fast, and the easiest way to learn what is happening in town.

Rules and deadlines can change. Check flhsmv.gov and your county property appraiser and tax collector for the latest. This is general information, not legal or tax advice.

FLORIDA GROUPS WORTH KNOWING

Turtle Patrol, Florida State Parks. Volunteers walk nesting beaches at sunrise with park staff, spring through October.

Florida Master Naturalist Program. UF/IFAS courses all over the state, full of curious, outdoorsy locals.

Master Gardeners. Through your county's UF/IFAS extension office. Florida gardening is its own sport.

Surfrider Foundation chapters. Beach cleanups up and down both coasts.

U.S. Coast Guard Auxiliary. For boaters: safety classes, patrols, and a crew that becomes your crew.

SIGNS YOU *belong*

Someone at your regular spot knows your order.

You run into people you know at the grocery store.

Your phone has texts from people you met here.

Someone invites you to something you didn't plan.

When a storm comes, you know who to check on, and who will check on you.



An evening walk on the beach.

STILL PICKING YOUR TOWN?

Where you land shapes who you'll meet. A fishing village, a walkable downtown and a golf community make for very different first 90 days. Our free eight question quiz matches you to the Florida beach towns that fit how you want to live.

SCAN TO TAKE THE QUIZ

or visit floridacoastal.co